The GDR's doping scheme would be repeated at other international events, including the 1988 Olympics, where Kristin Otto and other members of the record-shattering women's teams were pumped with performance-enhancing drugs. (Otto, winner of six gold medals, had steroid levels almost three times the limit needed to trigger a positive result. Finally, in the year 2000, Ewald and director of sports medicine, Manfred Hoeppner, received suspended sentences after being charged with causing bodily harm to 142 women through doping).

During the 70s, Honecker was also turning a blind eye to the unrestricted flow of narcotics passing into West Berlin from the GDR. Curiously enough, one of the attractions for the international trafficker, was the 'open-door' policy which meant West Berlin's large population of Turks could fly with Interflug into East Berlin's Schönefeld Airport carrying drugs and enter the West without customs controls.5

The trade – described by media as causing a 'heroin epidemic' – was serviced by many independent small sellers supplied in modest individual quantities via an army of go-betweens travelling to East Berlin from Turkey and the Middle East. In the early 1970s, overdose deaths were practically unknown in West Berlin, but by 1976, fifty-four people had died; in 1977, eighty-four overdosed. Over thirty victims were found dead in public places, in parks, public toilets, or the underground. As the alarming situation worsened, the US embassy delivered a stark warning to Washington of 'evidence that East Berlin is a transit point, but East German cooperation has not been forthcoming. Berlin has the potential of becoming another Amsterdam with concomitant political and security implications.' In a cable to Washington, the embassy noted:

An FRG ministry of health official raised the issue with his GDR counterpart in their last meeting. In a later response, the GDR expressed 'astonishment' that the FRG would speak for Berlin on a purely Berlin matter. Given this GDR attitude, our